

SPECTATORS OR PARTICIPATORS?

* Blue denotes PPT slide

* Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Habakkuk 3:19 (CEV) “ *The LORD gives me strength. He makes my feet as sure as those of a deer, and he helps me stand on the mountains.*”

INTRO: The third chapter of Habakkuk finds the prophet praying and cataloguing the mighty miraculous deeds of Jehovah. (this prayer is set to wild, enthusiastic, triumphal music) The enumeration of His deeds include:

- Creation...
- The plagues of Egypt...
- Israel's deliverance through the Red Sea...
- The sun standing still before

Joshua...

- The cursing of the fig tree...

Three times in nineteen verses he says Selah – Pause and calmly think about that!

Then in verse nineteen the prophet pray's, ***“The LORD gives me strength. He makes my feet as sure as those of a deer, and he helps me stand on the mountains.”***

The prophet is obviously mesmerized and somewhat fearful of the level of power at which God appears to operate. In his guarded trepidation he uses the analogy of the sure footedness of a deer on the steep slopes of a jagged mountain range.

It quickly becomes rather obvious that the prophet is attempting to encourage

himself and his reader audience to make life a participator sport rather than a spectator affair.

Many people prefer to sit snugly in a warm mountain lodge, satisfied with good food and comfortable surroundings, as they are lulled to sleep in comfort gazing upward, at tall mountain ranges. They love to hear stories about climbers who reached the highest peak against strong odds. They imagine the breath taking view from the top of a mountain but never actually witness such breathtaking altitudes.

In this culture being a spectator has become a common substitute for the real thing. The question becomes, “*Are we going to be spectators or participators?*” **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL POINT #1)**

One can never fully appreciate the view from the mountain of destiny unless we climb the mountain ourselves!

Daydreaming is never enough. We have to personally experience the realities of God, not just hear about someone else's spiritual highs.

Being armchair Christians leaves a lot to be desired!

We must stop being spectators and start climbing for ourselves! If we will dare to climb God will give us strength and make us as sure footed as a deer on a jagged mountain ledge.

In the Kingdom of God there are three things that are needed for us to accomplish the purpose God has called us to so that we can eventually stand on the breathtaking summit of our destiny.

- Teamwork...
- Endurance...
- Celebration...

Last week I rolled out a plan for this church to raise \$375,000 above the tithe before December 31st, 2015. When you first heard me say it some of you probably thought there is no way we can do that! That is a lot of money and the time frame is too short! Then I told you the plan to raise the \$375,000 – One dollar per day per person at CT through December 31st, 2015... That is a workable plan but three things are needed in order to accomplish the vision.

I. TEAMWORK...

As with almost everything else in life more can be accomplished with a team than with a solo effort. Some would say *“Wouldn’t it be easier if someone in this*

church would step up and write a \$375,000 check?” It would be much easier if this would happen but the rest of us would not be permitted to participate on the team and enjoy the journey!

For \$375,000 to be raised with each person giving a dollar-a-day for 266 day's, 1,410 people must participate. I ask you, *“Is the trip better with a solo participant or with more than 1,400 people traveling to the same destination?”* **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

Teamwork is a beautiful thing! On March 28,1990 Michael Jordan scored 69 points and his teammate Stacey King scored one point in a 117-113 victory over the Cavilers. When asked about this by a reporter Stacey said *“I’ll always remember this as the night Michael*

Jordan and I combined to score 70 points.”

Teamwork is work but great things happen for people who are willing to work to accomplish a goal.

For teamwork to operate at its optimum level everyone must be focused in on the goal. **What is the goal? (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Students receiving a character based education...
- The lives of children being changed...
- Family history's being rewritten...

It is one thing to climb to the top alone; it is quite another thing to have a team to celebrate with when we arrive.

II. ENDURANCE...

When we are traveling alone we have to

keep ourselves encouraged and motivated. When we are seeking a goal with a group of friends we feed off of each other for endurance. (Example of Susan and I in ministry – When one of us has been ready to quit the other is motivated to move forward)

We gain confidence and grow stronger every time we push ourselves to do something we were not sure we could do.

The prophet uses the analogy of a deer on the mountain slopes. He describes the surefootedness of this animal. ***“My feet as sure as those of a deer...”*** As surefooted as each of us may be there comes a time when our feet slide and we need an extra dose of endurance!

Psalm 121:3 (AMP) “He will not allow your foot to slip or to be moved; He Who keeps you will not slumber.”

Let's be honest... For us to have an adequate supply of endurance to accomplish our goal we will need the help of the Lord. We will also need to rely on the strength of our brothers and sisters!

Let me assure you that not everyone who stands on a mountaintop parachuted in!

For a climber to endure when the muscles are aching is character formation at its best! The pain must be ignored to reach the goal! **What is the goal? (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Students receiving a character based education...
- The lives of children being changed...
- Family history's being rewritten...

III. CELEBRATION...

For a team to be successful there must be times of celebration. Before one can stand on the pinnacle of success and celebrate a monumental accomplishment there must be some small and intermediate wins that can be celebrated.

Celebration is the fuel that drives a team to success. In order for our ultimate goal to be accomplished we must get a...

- Day of success under our belt...
- A week of successful teamwork behind us...
- A month of marching together in our rear view mirrors...

Sometimes we find ourselves in the dilemma of not wanting to slip backwards but not sure we can move forward! Remember, we cannot reach the view at the top without pressing

through to celebration. Deuteronomy 33:27 (CEV) *“The eternal God is our hiding place; he carries us in his arms. When God tells you to destroy your enemies, he will make them run.”*

Over the next 266 day's we are going to celebrate together the accomplishments the Lord is going to help us to have as we become as surefooted as a deer on the mountain ledges of this journey.

CONCLUSION:

At the end of the day our ultimate goal is not \$375,000 - It is... **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME AND LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL END OF SERVICE)**

- Students receiving a character based education...
- The lives of children being changed...
- Family history's being rewritten...

Mark your calendar's for Sunday,
January 3rd, 2016! We are going to have
a church wide party and celebrate for
the successful conclusion of the dollar-
a-day campaign.

On January 3rd, 2016 are you going to
engage in the celebration saying, look
what the Lord helped us do, or look
what they did?